Sky Vandal

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34525570.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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F/F

Fandom:
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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), She-Ra (She-Ra)

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Trans Adora (She-Ra), Flashbacks, Modern AU, But there's still magic, Magicat Catra (She-Ra), Angst, Fluff and Angst, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, OC parents because Shadow Weaver sucks, Chronic Illness, Putting the stars in The Fault in Our Stars, Catra and Adora always loved each other, I am so sorry for this, Alternate Universe, catradora

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by Mal_content

Summary

Adora was a terrible liar, but not when it came to Catra; reassurances she didn't quite believe and promises she wouldn't get a chance to keep. She felt sick when she swore things to Catra neither of them would have time to give, but she needed so badly to hear it, and Adora could never deny her anything. She would give her the entire world if it was her wish, impossibilities aside. They didn't hold a candle to her feelings for Catra, anyway.

[Or the urban fantasy queer retelling of The Fault in Our Stars that nobody asked for]

Notes

Exactly one year after finishing She-Ra and I've finally put together one (1) fanfiction! Hurray!

So I was just minding my business, scrolling through TikTok, when I came across the latest project of an animation student I follow (@/keetz.me) - a collaboration called "Sky Vandal", which immediately made me think of Catradora. Angst, predictably, followed and so did motivation, so here you go.

Trigger warning for mention of death/hospitals.

See the end of the work for more notes

Usually when Adora ran, her ears filled with white noise that sounded something like screaming, urging her to keep going when anybody else's body would have given out. She was used to the feeling, like her entire body was vibrating and buzzing like crazy to keep her pushing forwards.

There was no buzzing now, no screaming. It was a new kind of rush, to be filled with utter and complete silence, unaware of the world around her aside from the rhythm of her pounding steps and the beat of her heart. She felt like a super soldier in an action movie, when they ran in slow motion and dramatic music played, but there wasn't anything like that. Just internal stillness, rhythm, and unrelenting purpose.

Maybe someone would look over and exclaim something as she ran past - Adora was pretty sure she was moving faster than the average person should be able to - but if they did, she didn't hear it. She was there and gone, tunnel vision in full effect.

The city was noisy and alive all around her, but she blocked it out and ran like her life depended on it. Even if it wasn't hers depending on this.

But someone else spent their time depending on *her,* trusting her, and she may as well have been Adora's life for all Adora felt for her. Adora didn't doubt that she could probably run faster for Catra than she ever could for herself.

Catra didn't know she was here, or that she was running. She might have been thinking about her, though. Catra was always thinking about her.

Adora kept running, and running, and she thought about Catra, too.

Catra purred, curling into Adora's side. Catra didn't purr often anymore; the natural magicat instinct left her breathless when her chest was already tight, and it was easier for her to display affection with lazy headbutts and clinging hands. But she purred now, for the few minutes that she and Adora stole for themselves on the rooftop. Adora had missed her gentle purring.

"It sucks we live in the city," Catra muttered, her head still tucked under Adora's chin. Adora stroked her hair absentmindedly, circling back when she reached the ends at the nape of Catra's neck. "I wish there were stars here."

"There are stars," Adora said, in the quiet voice she reserved for Catra. She wasn't sure when she started using it - maybe when Catra started sitting so close Adora was afraid her voice might hurt her sensitive ears, or maybe when their time alone together became so fragile and intimate she worried too loud a word might break it. "It's just too light to see them."

Catra made a noise that might have been a snort, if it weren't for the device in her nose that delivered her oxygen. "Fine then, Dr Adora-Space-Expert. I wish it was *darker.* I want to see stars."

The other words were left unspoken, but Adora knew they were there. *Before I die.*

Everything had come to circle around that now, wishes and fantasies added to a quick-growing bucket list and no set amount of time to check through everything. They both knew that stars were unlikely. Catra was too sick to make any trip that far outside the city.

"Maybe one day," Adora said gently. She was a terrible liar, but not when it came to Catra, reassurances she didn't quite believe and promises she wouldn't get a chance to keep. She felt sick when she swore things to Catra neither of them would have time to give, but she needed so badly to hear it, and Adora could never

deny her anything. She would give her the entire world if it was her wish, impossibilities aside. They didn't hold a candle to her feelings for Catra, anyway.

Catra didn't want anything as crazy as the entire world, though. Just the stars.

Thousands of people in the world had access to the stars every single night, and yet as Adora fought to come up with something, she thought maybe the entire world might have been an easier task to handle afterall.

The building loomed, out of place on the outskirts of the bustling city. It was short and squat, one story that took up too much space on the ground. It was bright from the outside, but not from the same twinkling lights that lit up the rest of the city, instead plastered with garish white lights that made it look like a creepy lab facility in a horror movie. It was made of concrete, like some kind of dystopian bunker, and Adora found herself shuddering as she ran over the bridge toward it.

She and Catra had driven past it once or twice when they were little, wrinkling their little noses and talking about painting it bright, beautiful colours.

"There's enough room on the walls to paint lots of big pictures," Adora observed, her breaths fogging up the car window.

"We should do that. If it were any prettier, it would be nice enough to make it our palace," Catra had said matter-of-factly.

Adora wasn't concerned about making it prettier tonight, even if the memory made her lips curl with a smile. Her steps had slowed to a slightly more human pace, thumping on the hard ground of

the bridge and crunching into the gravel that came after. She was out of breath, having run more in under an hour than she usually did in a semester of gym class. She wasn't sure how much of that was to do with magic, and how much of it was pure determination.

She didn't care. She just continued towards the building, ignoring the mounting ache in her sides, going over hazy outlines of a plan in her mind.

Catra was in hospital for months on end after her first admission. Adora had to leave her side eventually, though not without protest, and she brought things from Catra's apartment to her after school. Catra wasn't up for doing much, even with the cocktail of drugs delivered to her via IV, so Adora mostly curled up as close to her side as she could get and they waited out the hours together.

"Look what Ren brought for me!" Catra squealed with excitement when Adora arrived one day, the door not even shut behind her. Ren was the name Adora used for one of her parents, preferring something outside the gendered terms of mom and dad, and Adora's heart clenched to hear Catra using the same title. Even more to hear her ren had come to visit the hospital and bring a gift for Catra.

She started to walk toward the bed, but Catra gestured for the light switches by the door. Adora hesitated for a moment like she always did, concerned she'd hit the wrong switch by accident and power down Catra's most vital equipment, but she managed to turn off the lights without mishap.

She trotted over to Catra's bedside, curious as she fiddled with something in her lap. A few moments later, light filled the dim

room, and Adora gasped over Catra's cackle of pure glee.

The dome in her lap sent light bouncing over the walls in the shapes of constellations. Adora looked from one wall to the next, up at the ceiling, taking in the beautiful stars.

"It was theirs when they were a kid," Catra explained. "They weren't sure if it would work, but they said they thought I'd like it while it lasted. It makes the hospital room much nicer."

Adora's heart was fit to bursting. She loved her parents, and she loved them even more for loving Catra. "It's so beautiful. And so thoughtful, too."

Catra shuffled in the bed. "Come and sit next to me. Stargaze with me."

Adora did, leaning Catra's head against her shoulder and resting her own head over hers, careful of her delicate ears. She watched as the light flickered a few times, not as bright as before.

"Ren said they put new batteries in it," Catra murmured, tapping the side of the small dome. "It's pretty old, though. How long do you think it will last?"

Adora was quiet for a second. She'd only just noticed the way that some of the stars showed up on Catra's cheeks, lighting the planes of her face and putting light back into eyes that had seemed dull and tired for months now. She'd thought several times that she was beginning to look like a ghost, but this was a different kind of ethereal. Beautiful and delicate rather than frail and breakable.

"Not as long as you," she answered. It was more of a hope than anything, but it got Catra to curl into her either way.

The building was easier to break into than Adora anticipated. There was no one present to keep her away, and though the doors were locked, it took her less than five minutes to find a "secret" back door with a key tucked to one side of it.

It was darker inside than it was outside, the bright fluorescent lights replaced with slightly dimmer strips of light along the floor. It cast the long, winding hallways in white-blue light, growing dark by the ceiling and giving the whole place an intensely eerie vibe. Adora felt like she was about to become the protagonist in a horror movie, but she kept going, running as quietly as the linoleum floors would allow.

Slowly, the hallways wound tighter and windows opened up on the walls, showing control panels and techie equipment that Adora couldn't figure out if she tried. The windows got bigger, until they took up whole walls, and so did the machines behind them, morphing from keyboards and screens to gears the size of her head. It was nothing she'd ever seen before, nothing she could make sense of.

But she didn't need to understand it. She just needed to get to the heart of it - wherever she could cause the most damage.

Adora hated the sound of the BiPap. She loved the device, how it kept Catra alive and breathing and helped her through terrible fits without having to admit her to the hospital, but the huffy whirring noises had always grated her just so. Maybe it was only because she knew the noises meant Catra was in pain. That was probably what she hated most.

The BiPap was originally just used to help Catra sleep, and usually it meant she was more comfortable; letting the machine do her breathing for her, trusting that it would keep her alive. But she now had days when breathing became so difficult that she needed to use it when she was awake, too. That was the bit that freaked Adora out. That it was getting worse.

Catra was whimpering into Adora's shoulder, and she was holding her so close, doing her best to soothe her - not that a chronic condition making it difficult to breathe was really something to be soothed away. The hand that wasn't in Catra's short hair was on the TV remote, one-handedly searching as she clutched onto Catra and murmured that she was alright. Catra turned slightly, blinking at the screen as Adora's chosen video started to play.

The screen was filled with stars. The voice narrating was smooth, with an accent that made it sound like they were speaking in cursive, and the lines that slid across the screen to connect the constellations together were a pastel shade of purple-blue, easy on the eyes.

Catra was still wheezing into the oxygen mask, pain written over her frail body, but she looked distracted, content to watch the documentary for a while as she settled. Her tail stopped lashing the pull-out bed beneath them in favour of curling around Adora's leg, the occasional twitch giving away her struggle even as she otherwise calmed down.

Adora couldn't fix Catra, heaven knows she'd tried. She couldn't make her better or take it all away. No one could, but she in particular felt like she'd failed her by that.

All Adora could do was be there, as she'd always been, long before Catra even got sick in the first place. As Catra had been there for her, right from the beginning when she'd made friends with the little boy down the hall who claimed he wanted to be a princess.

Back then, Catra had given Adora dresses and nicknames and written stories about a beautiful hero, rife with powerful magic and good at everything Adora was not. Now, Adora gave Catra all the time she had in the world, her dedication and attention and nights spent wide awake. To someone else, it would sound like a lot, to give another person your everything.

But Adora knew it wasn't even close to enough.

The elegant hallways swerved further, spiraling into the depths of the enormous building until Adora knew she couldn’t go any deeper without getting lost. She didn’t need to travel past this point, anyway. She just needed to be in the vicinity of as many of the machines as possible.

She took a deep breath, despite her exertion causing her to breathe harder than usual. She’d never been great at concentrating on this part, but her mind had never been clearer than it was now. She was centered. Focused. She knew what she was doing, what she wanted. She felt herself sink deeper, until consciousness and focus turned to sparks and swirls of magic, surging like the ocean in a storm.

Magic was rare, these days, in a predominantly human society. Neither of Adora’s parents had any power to speak of, and even the magic users she did know had barely a lick of power compared to what their ancestors must have once possessed. To most people, magic was simply a rare gimmick, a trick of the eyes playing on a rush of confusion or a flash of sparkles.

But Adora’s magic was never like that. Her lineage must have traced back to one of the oldest magic users, heralded as a god more often than a warrior, strong enough for their power to show up in someone born thousands of years after their fall. Adora

possessed wells of magic, all-consuming and capable of conquering whatever she saw fit. She'd only ever had cause to use it once before, and aside from that, she'd been content to let it lie mostly dormant within her.

She'd never seen herself spending it here, and yet she felt little hesitation as she rallied her strength. This would be worth it, she knew it.

Her loose hair floated around her in a halo as she pulled her power to the surface, every inch of her glowing golden. She didn't have as much power as the last time this rush had filled her, but she didn't need so much this time. Just as long as she saved a little for later.

Her power glowed around her in the air. She had forgotten this part, the flurry in her chest as she saw herself turn to gold, ribbons of bright colours swirling around her like rainbows. Those strings of power pulsed and swelled, waiting for her direction, and she moved them almost idly through the air. She was all too happy to comply.

A yell escaped her as she thrust the magic outwards, as far as she could make it reach, targeting the innermost workings of every generator in the plant. One after the other, she heard the magic clashing with the electrics and bursting, sending sparks and waves of power flying outwards. Some of the glass windows cracked, but Adora didn't flinch. Not even when all the lights in the building went out once and for all, her glow the only thing to see by now.

Outside the building, the entire city went dark.

Adora hadn't known a lot of fear in her life, outside of childish nightmares and the pounding in her chest when they had to do

evacuation drills at school, but she was pretty confident she would never experience the same bone-deep terror as the night Catra first went to the hospital.

She'd been adamant that Catra needed to see a doctor when she'd confessed having trouble breathing several weeks ago, but she hadn't been aware how serious it was until she'd woken up to screams coming from Catra's apartment, Catra's mother yelling over the top of it in a futile attempt to try and calm her hysterical panic.

When Adora had seen Catra strapped into the stretcher, a breathing mask pressed over her face and writhing as she was carted down toward the waiting ambulance, her heart had nearly stopped dead in her chest. She'd never seen her friend look so small, so breakable, than in that moment.

Adora waited in the hospital for hours, sometimes trying to comfort C'yra in her shaken silence and other times pacing, trapped in her own head. She couldn't remember how long she'd been awake. She didn't think she'd ever sleep again.

Her parents had left her here, promising to come and retrieve her in the morning. She hadn't seen Catra yet and she wasn't ready to go home without her - the only luck she had was that she had no clue what time it was.

It wasn't really any consolation at all.

She overheard a murmured conversation between C'yra and one of the doctors, clearly trying to keep her from listening in. Adora's bones were guttering with dread anyway; there was no mistaking the looks in their eyes, the way C'yra's tail twitched and went limp behind her. She was going to lose Catra.

She couldn't bear to lose Catra.

Catra was sleeping when the doctors let C'yra and Adora in to see her - to say their goodbyes, though they didn't say that out loud. Adora wasn't sure what else this visit could be.

Catra was twitching, pain written all over her even in a drug-induced sleep. Adora had never been so distraught.

"I can't lose her," she said, the first thing she'd said so far. She turned to the doctors, pleading. "Please. This is what you do. Save her. For me, for C'yra, save her!"

The doctors, for their part, looked mournful as well. "Her condition is… too far past. If we'd gotten to her sooner…"

The doctor went on, saying something specific and technical about her condition and the procedures. C'yra looked past devastated, clearly latching onto the same words Adora was - *if we'd gotten to her sooner…*

Adora zoned out of the conversation, staring with wide eyes at her best friend in the whole world. Hair mussed, chest moving too hard, fast and irregular. She was soaked with sweat and twitching restlessly, clearly in agony. The girl who teased Adora mercilessly and pretended to fight her through giggles, who held her when she cried and came to her when she was hurting.

Catra, Catra, Catra. She was Adora's world, and every one of her limited thoughts - *Catra, Catra, Catra…*

She didn't notice when the doctors left, hardly registering when she and C'yra came to Catra's bedside, clutching each of her hands tight. They were damp with sweat, and still so small. Catra had always been small, waiting to grow bigger and catch up with Adora.

Adora's throat felt like it was closing up when she pressed on the pads of her tiny fingers, making her claws slide out from under her skin. Just like she'd done when they were kids and still learning how they worked. Suddenly the world was blurry, tears pouring down her face, and she was shaking and trying not to scream, because how could she hold this in?

Catra had never been quiet. She'd been a forest fire their whole lives, wild and loud and untamed and beautiful. Quiet tears and

silent mourning would never do her justice. Adora was going to scream and scream and destroy the whole world, no matter if she burned herself apart in the process. She could do that. She was powerful beyond what she knew, she could destroy anything she wanted -

She gasped through tears, violent shakes turning to careful tremors. She wiped her face, desperate to regain some of her senses beyond hearing. All she could hear was the beep of Catra's heart monitor, jumping and then slowing like she was running out of fight.

"C'yra," she struggled to say through sobs. She needed to calm herself down, needed to be still and centered and focused. "Did Catra ever tell you my secret?"

For a minute, she thought C'yra would brush her off, telling her it wasn't the time. But after a moment of quiet, she shook her head. "No. She told me so much, but never any of your secrets."

Adora released a noise, somewhere between a laugh and a sob, more to let it out than anything. "I'm She Ra."

C'yra gave her a puzzled look. Adora knew that she was recalling the comics Catra had drawn and shown her when they were kids, showing Adora as an all-powerful magical princess - Catra scribbled hastily at her side.

Catra had started drawing them when the kids at school had told Adora she couldn't be a princess, as a way to assure her, and it had become a game. Catra had drawn lots of She Ra - sometimes, Adora still saw her doodling her alter ego when she was bored.

"You're a princess to me. You don't have to be their princess - because you're a warrior-princess, and your kingdom moves all the time, see? So they're not in your kingdom, and they don't matter. Nothing matters, Adora. Just you and me."

C'yra blinked, wiping her eyes. "I know," she said slowly, confusion washing over some of the grief on her face.

Adora shook her head. She could already feel some of the buzz, but she knew she had to be more concentrated if she had any hope of this working. "No. For *real.* Well, except for the princess part, I guess. But she's really… I'm…" She shook her head again. "I don't know how to do this, I don't know if it'll work. But I have to try. For her, and you, I - we can't lose her. I have to try," she echoed.

C'yra's eyes widened, apparently understanding what Adora meant, finally. "Do you need -"

"I just need to concentrate," Adora murmured. "Maybe… step back a little."

She had gone to a sort of magic counseling once, like a summer camp for kids with powers to help them learn to control it. She vaguely remembered being told that she had unusually high levels of power, but she spent most of the camp unable to summon even a shimmer of it.

"She just needs to focus," one of the counselors had said. *"If she learns to keep her mind grounded, concentrate on the magic… there's no telling what she'll be able to do."*

Adora wasn't very good at focusing, and she was bored at camp anyways. Her mind always wandered partway through an exercise, wondering what Catra was up to at home without her. That was part of the reason why She Ra had so much power in Catra's stories - because Adora had told her all about her magic and her inability to use it, and about how terrible she felt to be so useless. Catra had *never* let her feel useless.

Adora had never needed magic before, not on the level that She Ra used. She knew she had more than any documented magic user in the last couple of decades, but now she was trembling with the fear that what she had wouldn't be enough.

She forced her muscles to relax, her mind to concentrate. She told herself to forget about the report card she got from school every

year, *trouble focusing* outlined several different times - she was going to do it this time. For Catra.

Catra, with her scratchy laughter and the fang that stuck out over one lip. The way she denied feeling any kind of affection for Adora but went home and drew comics of Adora overcoming everything that ever worried her. The way she watched her when nobody was looking, and the way Adora did the same.

Every thought screamed of *Catra, Catra, Catra* as Adora sunk into herself, feeling the magic build up all around her. She'd felt something similar at the magic camp once, but it was nothing compared to the intensity of this. She felt her blood thrumming in her veins, and dared to squeeze her eyes open just a little to see her body bathed in a golden glow, becoming more and more intense with every ounce of magic she dredged up. As she delved deeper and deeper, a little voice in her head warned her she would never have this much power again.

She didn't care. It had been well worth saving, and well worth being used now.

She reached out blindly as ribbons of colour started to unspool from within her, shimmering and floating in the air. Her hair formed a halo around her as she found Catra's hand and clutched it tight. She watched the glow travel over her as well, rustling through her fur and limning everything with gold.

"Please be enough. Please heal her," she murmured to herself as she squeezed Catra's hand. C'yra was still watching with wide eyes, shaking where she stood beside Catra's slowing monitor. Another tear escaped Adora's eyes, and she squeezed them shut, reaching with her power to Catra. "I've got you. I've always got you. Come home to me."

Adora's power rushed out of her and into Catra, so intense it left her breathless. She hoped all her breath went into Catra instead. She hoped, beyond all reason, she was enough to keep her holding on, for just a little while longer.

Nobody could ever figure out what kind of magic it was that hummed in Adora's veins, surging and impossible. Most magic-users, with their puny threads of magic, had some particular kind of magic - water, or ice, or wind. Adora's magic had never been just one thing; it was simply power, shaped however she willed it.

Looking around, things were still whirring, but everything was dark. That was even better than Adora had planned it - she'd plunged the whole city into a blackout without actually stopping anything other than the lights. It was perfect, actually.

Adora moved fast, directing her magic into her limbs on purpose this time to give her the boost she needed. She sprinted down the maze of curved hallways, the lights gone now, and let her own glow light her back to the door. She knew she was conspicuous, now the only light in a city of darkness, but she had no other way to get home without magic. She was going to have to take her chances, and hope she still had something left when she got there.

She didn't care much who saw her. They weren't fast enough to catch her - they probably didn't even think she was human, given the circumstances. Every light in the city had gone out at once, leaving everyone in confusion, and then there was a mirage of glowing golden light streaking past them. They probably thought her a sign of the apocalypse, or some kind of undead ghost of magic.

She didn't need to be careful, thrumming with power as she was, but she still heard Catra's scolding in her head as she weaved through the traffic, vaulting off the hoods of cars and using threads of glowing magic like grappling hooks to propel herself

toward the center of the city, the apartment with the pillowfort on the rooftop and the magicat girl on the top floor.

Catra would be there, waiting for her. And Adora would be back any minute now.

Catra was in the middle of a new She-Ra drawing when the power suddenly went out - a flicker of warning, then darkness, the lights buzzing with the sudden loss. Her ears perked up, listening until it faded into nothing. The apartment was unfamiliar without the hum of electricity, and yet it wasn't silent, either - everything was still working, except for the lights.

Adora's dad, Vance, jumped up from his spot in Catra's kitchen, cursing. He and his partner Lei took turns coming in here to keep an eye on Catra on the nights Adora was out, her mother busy working the night shift, and tonight it was Vance working from the bench in the squashy kitchen.

His anxiety over what the lack of power would mean for Catra and her medical equipment quickly turned to confusion, when they found that everything else was still working. More of an inconvenience than a danger, but he still insisted that she didn't turn on the TV just yet, just in case. In case of *what* she wasn't sure, but she couldn't really be bothered to argue.

With nothing worthwhile to do, she found herself sitting on one of the barstools at the kitchen counter, surrounded by candles and talking idly with Vance and Lei. They had rushed over almost as soon as the building went dark, and now they were speculating about the outage and the strangeness of the situation. After a few minutes of feigning interest, Catra zoned out of the conversation and turned back to the contact open on her phone.

It was lying face up on the countertop beside her, waiting for a message from Adora. She'd been 'running errands' in the city, in Lei's words, which was why she wasn't here to tease and annoy her, and Catra was a little worried about her. If the whole city was dark, and not just their apartment, Adora would have her phone out for light, and yet the receipt beside her earlier messages still said *delivered.*

Catra and Adora were good at worrying about each other, and the fact that Adora wasn't busy worrying about her right now had Catra feeling a little worried herself. Still, she tried to press it down as best as she could. Adora deserved a life outside of Catra, and it was better that she found one now so she had something to turn to when Catra wasn't there anymore.

Catra was still contemplating those dismal thoughts, tracing a claw along the patterns in the marble, when there was a crash from the hallway, followed shortly by the front door bursting open. Adora was standing there, frazzled and out of breath, the hair falling out of her ponytail and laying askew around her face.

Catra did nothing to hide her surprise, letting her tail flick around the barstool. "What are you doing here? Did - did you run here from the city? How fast did you climb all those stairs?"

Adora grinned, shaking her head and gulping down air. She didn't answer any of Catra's questions, even as she took a couple of steps closer. "Come on. Come to the roof with me."

Cautious, Catra stood to meet her. She cocked her head to look her over, trying desperately to assess a situation that didn't make any sense at all. Adora smiled at her hopefully, still panting for breath, and Catra cracked with a sigh. "Let me get my jacket first."

Catra hadn’t been home from the hospital for very long yet. Every time she’d looked well enough to go home, something in her condition complicated and she went right back to where she started. The first couple of times she was successfully discharged, Adora’s family got her and C’yra a hotel room close to the hospital, just to be safe - and the first couple of times, it was just as well. But after managing to use her broken lungs without mishap for a week or so, Catra was finally back home.

She had been quiet on the ride over, pressed into Adora’s shoulder. She was quiet all the time now, Adora thought, her heart aching. They’d had moments of laughter together, but outside of it, Catra was completely silent, rid of even her usual sarcastic observations.

Adora wasn’t sure what to say to make it better. She’d been angsting over things that would help for weeks now, but she came up empty every time. Probably because she was just as anxious as Catra. Catra was alive, but the doctors had confirmed that outside of the *miracle* of her body accepting the initial treatment (thanks to She-Ra), it wouldn’t stay that way forever. Catra was terminal. She wasn’t going to school anymore and her life was irreversibly upside down. There wasn’t much more Adora could do for her.

“Hey,” Adora said, quiet so as not to startle her. She’d knocked on the side of the wall before speaking, but Catra still jumped a little when she saw her there. “How are you doing?”

Catra huffed a sigh out through her mouth, her nose taken up with the cannula that connected to her oxygen tank. Even life at home was different - Catra slept on the pull-out couch in the living room while C’yra took the single small bedroom, the space not big enough for Catra to keep her medical equipment and still move around. Logistically, Adora supposed it made sense, but it had to be hard to adjust to anyway. All the changes were difficult to keep track of.

"I'm okay, I guess," Catra conceded quietly. Her tail was flicking again, making *swish* noises on the couch cushions. "I don't…" She sighed again, pausing. "I don't know what to do anymore."

They had talked at length the other night, Catra explaining that going home was meant to be the reset button that turned everything back to normal. Adora knew what she meant; she'd been waiting for it all to go away, too. Catra didn't bring any of that up again now, but Adora knew she was just trying to avoid the vulnerability of the conversation, searching for a little edge when everything in life made her uncomfortably vulnerable now.

"Are you okay to walk around a little?" Adora asked, going a little closer to the couch. "We can go sit in my room for a bit, if you want."

Catra smiled a little. It was a new smile, genuine but weak, like sunlight filtering through clouds that weren't quite thin enough to turn it to a rainbow. Adora was uneasy - she missed Catra's old smiles, wicked, untamed, fang poking over one lip. She missed her old Catra, who had everything left to live for and nothing to hold her back.

"Okay," she said, reaching for Adora's hand. Adora hoped she'd twist it, pinning it behind her back and letting her know she was still *in there.* It wasn't likely, but it didn't even have to be a very good pin. Catra only held her hand carefully and walked with her out of the living room.

Adora listened to the squeak of the wheels on Catra's oxygen tank as they walked the short hallway toward Adora's apartment. She remembered being told off by neighbors when she and Catra were little, running about and squealing where there was space for them to fight and play. She squeezed Catra's fingers a little tighter in her own.

"I'm sorry everything has changed," Adora murmured as they got inside the apartment, closing the door behind them and passing the kitchen. Catra made a quiet noise of surprise when Adora

didn’t turn the lights on, barely noticeable. “And I’m sorry that things are a little different here, too. But sometimes change is good, and I… I was hoping this would be a good different.”

Before Catra could ask her what she was acting so weird about, she was at the door to her bedroom, pulling it open, and Catra went completely, utterly silent.

It was something Adora had been working on in fits and starts since Catra had been in hospital. She’d wanted it to be for Catra’s room, but when checking with C’yra, they’d decided that Catra would need to be moved to the living room and Adora figured it was better here than nowhere. They’d had to get permission from the landlord, too - that’s what had taken the longest. But he had caved, and it had come together, and now it was here.

The room was dark without the lights on, or dim at least. The low light revealed messy splotches of glowing paint from wall to ceiling, adorning pretty much every visible surface. Stars, and constellations - at least, it was meant to be. Adora had spent hours trying to plan it out, sketching everything, but her painting skills were still wobbly and it wasn’t anything stunning. The distance between each star had been mapped perfectly, but she doubted that was the part Catra would be impressed with.

Adora bit her lip, gauging Catra’s reaction. She wasn’t sure whether or not Catra was disappointed by the wobbliness of the stars, some of them too big or too small and a couple of them not stars at all, just smudges of paint where Adora had messed it up -

She was still quiet, eyes wide and jaw dropped open as she took in the room. Adora didn’t know how to take it.

“It’s a bit messy,” she said, trying to see where Catra was at. Her voice was a little unsteady. She gestured weakly to the room. “I tried really hard, but the paint was always runnier than I expected it to be, and I’m just not a very good painter, and I -”

“You’re an idiot,” Catra interrupted her. Adora’s heart wasn’t even finished dropping when she noticed the shine of tears on Catra’s face, and heard the choke in her voice. “You did this? For me?”

Adora shrugged, her own vision growing blurry now. She wasn’t expecting it to be this emotional; it was just paint, afterall. But it was important, and she was shaking. “Well, yeah. You liked the dome thing Ren got you so much, and you got so interested in stars, and you can’t see any here, so I wanted to do something, you know? It was going to be in your room, but C’yra said you were moving into the living room, and then we thought you were coming home and I wanted it to be ready, and -”

She cut off at the sound of a strangled sob. Catra was *smiling* - this one so bright and vulnerable it made Adora’s knees quake. Catra hadn’t smiled like that since before the hospital, if ever.

“It’s perfect,” she managed to say. She took a step forward, burying her face in Adora’s shoulder. Adora’s arms circled around her back, holding her as close as she could without fear of hurting her. She closed her eyes, breathing her in. There was only fuzz on Catra’s head now, slightly thicker than the rest of her body but still not quite hair, and her fur was thinned and matted from the treatment. Even falling to pieces and changed as she was, she was still soft and sweet and *Catra.*

“I just wanted -” Adora started, only to have Catra cut her off again, leaning back and pressing a finger to her lips.

“Shh. It’s perfect. It’s more than I ever would have expected from *anyone,* and I have no idea how to respond to that.” Catra moved her finger away to stroke Adora’s cheek, more tears slipping free. Her smile wobbled, like all of Adora’s stars, and suddenly they looked that much more beautiful. “You’re so much more than I ever deserved, Adora.”

Adora pulled her back in, gentle, and held her close. “I’m just… me,” she mumbled. “I’m just good for you.”

Catra gripped her tightly, going quiet again. The lack of words wasn't concerning her anymore. She just held on to Catra and let the silence speak loud enough for the both of them.

Catra felt the cold creeping in before they even got to the roof, the draught slipping in and wrapping around her on the stairs. She shivered and felt Adora turn her attention to her.

"You okay?" Adora asked gently, helping to lift her oxygen tank up the stairs. Catra could tell she was trying to be careful with it, but she was still panting from whatever running she'd done to get here. Catra hadn't asked about it yet; she was too curious where Adora was going with this.

"I'm okay," she said, even as every step turned the air a little colder. She was glad she'd brought her jacket with her. "Adora, what are we doing?"

Adora grunted with the effort of lifting the tank, but she was grinning. "You'll see. You'll like it, I promise. Just keep walking."

Catra was surprised to find the door already open when she reached the top of the stairs, the reason for the early onslaught of cold fall air. She turned to look at Adora accusingly, who was still lugging the hefty tank with a sheepish look on her face. "I thought you were in the city when the power went out, not on the roof!"

Adora laughed, the sheepishness turning to mischief. "Go up there. Have a look."

Catra was near bursting with curiosity as she stopped and crouched down to guide Adora and the tank up the last couple of steps. She drank in the giddy hopefulness in Adora's eyes for a

minute, hauling the tank onto flat ground, and felt the anticipation ramp up even more. She watched her for just another second before standing up and turning around.

There were blankets, and cushions, and the same seats there always were. It was cozy and comfortable, set up just like it always was for New Years and whenever else they decided to have a night to themselves up here. Catra scanned the roof for something different, confused. “I don’t…”

Adora’s body was warm at her back as she came up behind her. Catra shuddered at the heat of her breath when she leaned down to whisper something, her fingers coming around to skim the underside of her jaw. “Look up.”

Catra had never been awake this late before. She was still little, and bedtimes were eight thirty at the latest (even though Adora could sometimes stay up until nine on the weekends!). But tonight she’d been woken up, late in the night, by her mother sitting on the edge of her bed, stroking her ears and whispering, *"Do you want to come to a party with Mom, Dad and Ren?"*

It was nearly *midnight,* her mother had said, zipping Catra into her warmest too-big coat and taking her up toward the roof. A new decade was about to start and it was apparently very important that Catra be present to celebrate it. Not that she was arguing. She got to stay up late and go to a party - her first time celebrating new years with the grown ups rather than catching up the next day!

It was like being alive in an entirely different world - like seeing a part of the future, or something she wasn’t meant to. She had never been up in the night for any reason other than sickness or nightmares, and certainly not for a *party.*

It was cold on the roof, and it was snowing a little bit. Catra still wasn't entirely sure what was going on, other than that Adora was there, their families were talking and laughing, and there was a timer counting down the seconds until midnight.

"Are you cold?" Adora asked her. She was bouncing in place, full of the same energy she always had. Her coat was about the same as Catra's, even though Catra already had fur to keep her warm. Catra might have been naturally insulated, but Adora had always been warm regardless, like a little hot water bottle.

She wasn't wearing her hood, though Catra supposed that she wasn't, either. She didn't like the way it pressed on her ears, and Adora liked to keep hers down so she could see her hair, now soft and growing down to her shoulders.

"No," Catra said, though she was a little chilly. She wouldn't admit that. "Are you?"

Adora shook her head, still bouncing up and down. She was looking at the countdown now. "It's almost New Years."

Catra grinned. Last year, she had slept over in Adora's apartment on New Years, the closest they got to a celebration - but clearly, her mother now thought she was old enough to join in the real party. She wasn't really sure why it was all so important, pestering her mother as they had gone up the stairs.

New Years was about a new beginning, she said. Starting over. It was about making promises and learning to do things better than last year. They had a party so they could acknowledge those things - the best and worst times of the last year, and what was to come in the next. It was extra important for the new decade, like an ultra-special new beginning.

Even if she didn't quite understand it all, Catra was excited to be a part of it. She and Adora were very good at making promises.

"It's a new decade. What are you going to promise?" she asked her now, tail flicking through the thin blanket of snowflakes slowly

falling.

Adora cocked her head, then smiled. “To be your friend.”

Catra’s tail lashed behind her, ears flicking as she flushed. She reached out, giving Adora’s shoulder a playful shove. “Not to *me,* dummy. What are you going to promise for New Years!”

Adora laughed, shoving her back. “I don’t know. Promises are supposed to be about what you want to be for the next year - kinder, smarter, stronger. You’re supposed to work on yourself,” she proclaimed wisely, clearly reciting the words from somewhere. She moved toward Catra again, but not to shove her. Instead, frost-bitten fingers laced with her own. “I just want to be your friend. That’s all I want to be.”

A surprised purr started up in Catra’s throat before she could stop it, and she leaned into Adora’s side without having to think about it.

“I want to be your friend, too,” Catra said quietly. The words felt dangerous, even though she and Adora had been friends for years now. Even quieter, she added the scariest word of all. “Forever.”

Adora pulled an arm around her and held her close while their parents counted down the seconds to midnight.

“Adora,” Catra breathed. She was shaking, and she didn’t know how to stop.

“It’s okay,” Adora murmured, moving a little closer. She was practically plastered to Catra’s back now, her arms slipping loosely around her waist. “I’ve got you.” A pause, somewhere between awkward and anxious. “Do you like it?”

Catra had never left the city. She'd been watching movies and documentaries and whatever she could get her hands on since she'd first been hospitalized for her condition, and discovered she really loved the stars, looking at pictures and learning as much as she could about them from her place in the world, ensconced in the lights of the city. It was bright here. She had never seen the stars for real, the sky always blanketed in a thin film of light that all but obscured the sky above. The power had gone out before, of course, but the city had backup generators. It never lasted long, and it was never dark far enough to clear the sky properly.

But the whole city was dark, as far as the eye could see, and the sky above them was filled to the brim with stars.

Catra's tail lashed, catching between Adora's legs as she stammered desperately. "How… what… how did you…"

Adora leaned closer, resting her head in the crook of Catra's neck, and suddenly Catra got a whiff of her scent. The same intoxicating *Adora* that it had always been, laced with something sharp and new. Like sparks, like sherbet or popping candy or something else sweet and volatile. Catra had only ever scented it on Adora once before, before she knew better. Now she knew for certain that the smell was magic - She-Ra.

"You did it," she breathed. "You… you did… what did you do? You brought me the stars. How did you… you brought me the stars." Catra was sobbing through repeats of the same dumbstruck words. She didn't know how any of this was real.

Adora shushed her, drawing her closer still. "Come sit down with me. I'm staying right here."

She led Catra to one of the seats, still trembling uncontrollably. She shushed her again, warm and soft, and pulled Catra down to lie with her. Catra was sure the position was meant so she could see the stars, but the tears in her eyes made it hard to see anything at all.

“How did you do it?” Catra asked, quiet. She knew it was magic, and she knew Adora had the power for that, but she also knew why She-Ra had always been powerful in her comics - because Adora was not, and Catra couldn’t stand to see her beat herself up about it. Adora had been to camps and doctors and she had never managed to use her power. Something about focus. And yet that was the unmistakable scent of magic clinging to her, clearly responsible for the miracle of the stars above them.

Adora blew out a breath, playing with Catra’s ears like it would buy her time.

“I was never able to concentrate long enough to do magic,” she admitted, her own voice just as vulnerable. “I got distracted halfway through and started thinking of you.”

Catra made a surprised noise, warmth flooding through her. Adora laughed, rubbing the base of her ear to make her purr. “It turns out,” she continued, “it doesn’t matter how many times I think of you if you’re the one the magic is for. So you made it work.”

Catra didn’t know how to respond to that. “You turned out every light in the whole city.”

Adora chuckled. “Yep. That’s our little secret, though. I feel like some people won’t be as impressed with the stars as you are.”

Catra made another little noise of wonder, tucking her head down and nuzzling into Adora.

“I always keep your secrets,” she swore, fiddling with the cannula delivering her oxygen. The tubes tended to slip off when she lay down, designed to be worn over human ears rather than the headband Adora had fashioned for her years ago. She wiggled it back into place with one hand, the other unwilling to pull away from Adora.

Adora hummed something that sounded like a little smile, pulling her closer and breathing her in. Catra wondered what she smelled like, to Adora’s human senses. “I know.”

She looked up, first at the overwhelming love in Adora's face and then up at the stars. She was surprised at the familiarity of the formations, despite never having seen the night sky like this, when she realized she was looking at the exact same constellations painted up in Adora's bedroom.

"You really got it perfect," she muttered to herself, not really thinking about it.

Adora shifted to look at her better. "Hmm? What?"

Catra smiled. "The paint. It's exactly the same. It's perfect."

Adora shifted again, this time out of embarrassment. "I… I planned it out a lot."

Catra purred, rubbing her cheek against Adora's shoulder. "I know. That's because you're perfect, too."

All the air left Adora in a rush, and Catra laughed at how flustered she was.

"I'm not perfect," Adora protested. Like she hadn't just burnt out every light in the whole city just to *bring Catra the stars.*

"Whatever you say, princess," Catra sighed, snuggling back into her. She didn't miss the way Adora held her tighter in response.

Adora wasn't sure if Catra was laughing or purring. They were pressed together on the tiny bed, Catra's rumble vibrating through her, and Adora settled for the knowledge that Catra was, at least, *happy.*

“See? And that one’s the big dipper, over there. It starts with that star over the curtain rail, the one that’s shaped kind of like a five-pointed star, but I didn’t mean to do that, I swear -”

Catra really did laugh this time, the sound coarse and freeing. “Stop being such an idiot. This is ridiculous.”

Adora could tell from the tone of voice that Catra didn’t want to stop, but Adora still felt her cheeks heating with embarrassment. “Well. You said you wanted to go stargazing together, and these are the only stars we have…”

Catra hummed, leaning into Adora’s side. “The only ones we have *now.”*

Adora felt her throat close up, and she tried fiercely to get the tears to go away before they could start. She and Catra had always said they would travel the world one day - talked about holidays deep in the country or on a tropical island, both places with few enough lights they could indeed see the stars. That had to be what Catra was referencing, but Adora knew the possibilities of that dream had slipped out of their fingers the night Catra’s heart monitor had slowed to a near stop with her hand lying limp between Adora’s.

Sensing her shift in mood, Catra sat up, leaning over Adora and brushing the hair out of her face. “Adora. I want you to promise me something, okay?”

Adora put a gentle hand over the fingers brushing her face, holding her there. “Anything.”

Catra swallowed. Adora knew she wasn’t going to like it before she even proposed the promise.

“I want you to keep your old promises, all our old dreams. I want you to travel somewhere.” She gestured to the glow-in-the-dark room around them. “I want you to see the stars. I want you to do everything you promised me we would do together.”

Adora could feel her eyes filling up with tears. “Catra -”

“We never break our promises, Adora,” Catra whispered urgently. Adora could tell she was close to tears as well. “It’s nobody’s fault that this happened to me. We can’t do anything about the fact that I’m going to die, and we’re just lucky I’ve got to hold on this long with you. But it won’t last forever. Adora. Please.” She leaned closer, her shallow breaths warming Adora’s face. Adora was a little too aware of how Catra struggled to breathe when she got emotional, and tried to find a way to de-escalate the situation. “You won’t lose me when I die. I promise. Just promise me that you’ll live, that you’ll do the same things we always planned for.”

Adora let herself cry. She hadn’t cried in front of Catra once since everything had happened, but she allowed the tears to roll free down her cheeks for a few seconds before she caught herself. She pulled Catra close, burying her nose in her slowly regrowing hair and breathing her in, slowly.

“I promise,” she whispered, voice catching.

Adora had painted the constellations in her room so everything was in the same place in the sky that it would be during Catra’s birthday, though she’d never told Catra that. She didn’t know how else to pick a time, given that the sky changed so much throughout the year.

Catra’s birthday was still a few weeks away now, but everything was in the same general place that it was in the paintings. Catra told her it was perfect, and now that she had a comparison to the room she fell asleep in almost every night, Adora had to admit it was pretty close, if a little less wobbly in person.

Catra was purring, curled up against her side and watching the sky. Adora's heart felt like it was going to burst looking at her.

Adora had thought before, once or twice, about love and stars… the way that they were vast and endless, and interconnected even when they were so far from one another. How constellations formed shapes you could only see if you looked from the perfect angle, made up the lines in your head and pretended that it drew out the image you wanted it to. Love felt like that.

Looking at Catra now, the words *star crossed lovers* became different. Not something imperfect, two people destined to fall but never to love… only destined to love in a way that no one else could ever understand. It was in that promise Catra had made, so long ago - *you won't lose me when I die.*

Because she wouldn't be *gone,* that wasn't how death worked. Her purr would be gone, and her fang-showing smiles, and her coarse laugh and soft hugs. All of those things that Adora loved about the way she felt and smelled and moved… they would be irreplaceable, no way of getting them back.

But those weren't the things that had made her love Catra. They were side effects of a deeper love, one that came from the way Catra looked out for her, and understood her, and made her promises that no one else would dare to commit to. The important parts of Catra would never be gone. Those were the parts that she had given to Adora a lifetime ago, for safekeeping.

Anyone else would call them doomed or starcrossed, would see her death as the end of a lifelong love. But it wouldn't be. They were looking at the constellation of Adora and Catra from the wrong angle, and no one would ever understand loving her like Adora did.

"I love you," Adora whispered into Catra's hair. It wasn't the first time she'd said it, but it was the first time that the words made Catra go still.

I love you. She'd only ever said it when Catra was in pain, or afraid, or crying, holding her close and murmuring anything she could to soothe her. *Shh, it's okay. I've got you. I love you. You're okay. I'm right here.*

They both knew it - had always known it, really, that they were it for each other. But they'd danced around saying it out loud because for the most part, Catra's condition had them both afraid of hurting each other more than they'd already have to. But the moment was perfect, and Adora knew that nothing could ever hurt as bad as having Catra die without hearing the words.

For a moment, Catra said nothing, looking somewhere between the stars and Adora's face. Then she whispered, "I never wanted to hurt you. With any of this. But it's a little late to push you away now, and I'd only hurt you more."

"You don't need to push me away," Adora breathed. She stroked a careful strand of Catra's hair out of her face. "I'll let you break my heart. I'm asking you to, because there's no other way I can have you. We know how this ends. Just love me first."

Catra looked up, then closed her eyes. It was quiet enough that Adora could hear a gentle whistle coming from the nubbins that delivered her oxygen.

Finally, Catra turned her head into Adora's shoulder, rubbing her cheek against her collarbone and marking her with her scent. Her eyes were still closed when she mumbled, "I've always loved you. You know I have, right from the start. And right until the end. I promise."

Adora cupped the nape of Catra's neck, guiding her up from Adora's collarbone. For a few seconds, they were just looking at each other, hands on each other with reverent touches that had them barely moving at all.

"I can see the reflection of the stars in your eyes," Catra murmured. Adora shifted a little, so she was leaning up on her

elbows, and drew Catra in to kiss her.

Stars, I have seen them fall,
But when they drop and die
No star is lost at all
From all the star-sown sky.
The toil of all that be
Helps not the primal fault;
It rains into the sea,
And still the sea is salt.

- A. E. Housman

End Notes

I'd love to hear your thoughts if you want to leave a comment, or you can find me on Twitter as @/_grayspace !

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